his prescriptions to the Sangha—all reinforce the image of the monarch as virtually a Buddhist zealot. Surely, if this image of Ashoka as Buddhist sovereign is so obvious to us, it was also likely to have been the way in which his own subjects would have seen him. The archetypal Buddhist king that so often recurs seems clear evidence of how he had fashioned his image.

Yet there was another pivotal image, also nurtured in Ashoka's own lifetime and through his own edicts: of a compulsively communicative and accessible emperor seeking to reach out to his people, a sharer with them of his atonement for the carnage at Kalinga, a humane governor benevolently engaged with all living beings. In the Buddhist chronicles and texts there was no recollection of *this* persona, nor even the real reason for Ashoka's rethink on rulership in the wake of Kalinga. A similar amnesia marks the representations of events relating to his rulership in the art of ancient India. Storytellers and artists, instead of being attentive to the complexities and several aspects of Ashoka's own words, appear anxious to see him primarily through a Buddhist lens. Thus it was that the political genius of Ashoka faded away, just as knowledge of the scripts in which the words of the emperor were inscribed shrivelled into the dust. Ironically, even when those words came to be recovered and deciphered in the nineteenth century, artistic representations, as we saw with Tagore and Bose, continued to be anchored in Buddhist stories.

Closer to our own time, in the 1960s the artist Meera Mukherjee etched out a more nuanced historical Ashoka in the form of a massive metal sculpture. She is said to have cast Ashoka in this form as a protest against the violence of the Naxalite movement in Bengal during the 1960s.[56] The volume and size of Mukherjee's Ashoka suggests the great power of the emperor, but the sword turned down and the anguished face reflect his transformation at Kalinga (Fig. Epilogue 3).